

as without that he would have never made it to a prestigious institution like IIT Kharagpur, and also because the family's financial condition was not good enough to afford the education fees at that time. "We had a very tough time in terms of finances as a family," he adds. In fact, his father could never complete his graduation because of the tight finances, and Raja was also destined to start working after high school.

"Despite me not being a citizen of India, I was offered a scholarship by the government of India. That is why I want to do something for India," he says, sharing one of his biggest dreams—the dream of bringing the semiconductor manufacturing ecosystem to the country. He adds, "If I am able to do that, I am sure the same will open a lot of flood gates for Indians to come back to the country. Not just India, I think the whole world will be able to benefit from the same."

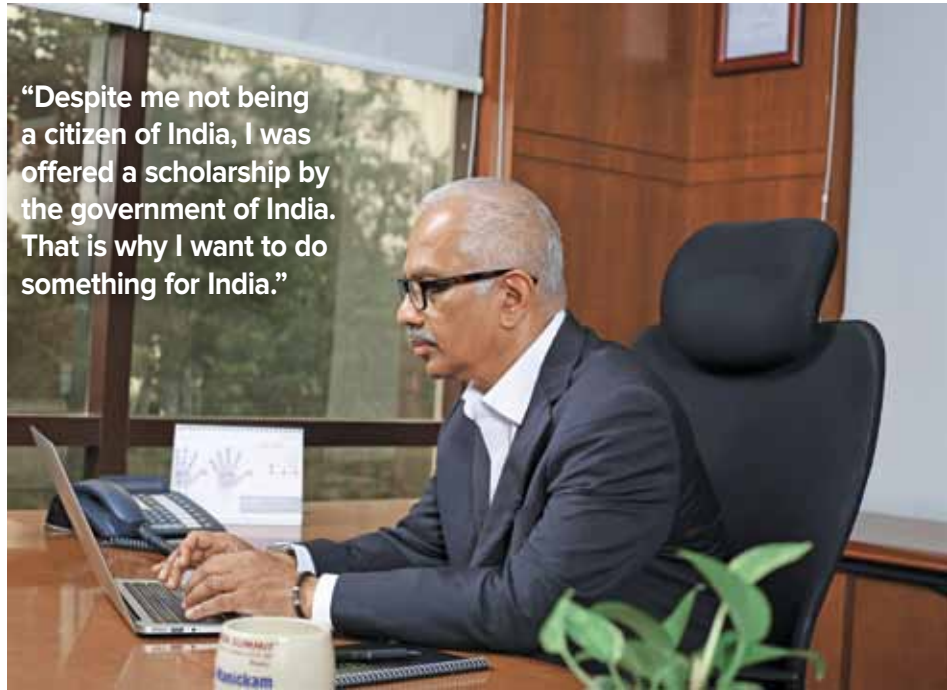
The scholarship that Raja was offered by the government of India included a sum of ₹400 credited to his account every month. This, when compared to the education, college, and hostel fee that Raja was paying at the IIT, was a big amount. The tuition fee at that time used to be around ₹25, while the exam fee used to be around ₹100. So, what did Raja do with the spare cash he was left with? Well, he helped economically poor students by paying their tuition and, in many cases, exam fees.

Raja recalls, "There were brilliant guys studying with me at the IIT, and some of them were facing tough times with finances. The excess money helped me fund the education of these guys. I think it's the background I came from that encouraged me to do so." He also got to lead at the college after becoming the hostel president. "I learned a lot of leadership skills in IIT," he adds.

First job: Baptism by Fire

Raja had a choice to study up to PhD on the scholarship that the government had provided, but as the eldest grandson, and as someone who was well aware of the financial condition his family was in, he opted to start working as soon as he got the degree from IIT Kharagpur. Though he had no

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idea about semiconductors, he applied for a job at Texas Instruments (TI) as TI was the most sought after company for electronics engineers back then.

"TI, despite being an American company, had no problem training employees irrespective of the country they belonged to. On the other hand, there were companies who were not ready to train people on the latest technologies they were working on. TI's eagerness to excel by training the best of knowledge to all equally was what attracted me to the company," Raja explains, and this point makes it clear how open he has been while making choices. There are always strong reasoning points in whatever he has done and achieved in life so far.

A lot of employees used to refer to TI as a pressure cooker. This was because when you are given training on the latest technologies, it is expected of you to deliver the very best of results. The pressure cooker, for Raja, was even higher because it was his first job straight out of college. His managers may or may not have expected a lot from him, but he always expected nothing but excellent work out of himself. "When you are young, and in your first job, you go through Baptism by Fire. You learn through your own mistakes, and you learn a lot," he shares.

The lesson of "Baptism by Fire" that he learnt from his innings with TI, and several other companies, can be clearly seen embedded in startup Tessolve Semiconductors that he founded. The young, as he points out, learn and become the best of themselves when they are pushed to the limits. The only point that this 'push to the limits' thing should include is open and equal transfer of knowledge to youngsters. He says, "I would tell every senior person at Tessolve to push youngsters to the limits without regret. However, be very open in transferring knowledge at the same time. Don't give them an easy life during the initial stages of their career."

His message to youngsters, "Learn the core fundamentals of what you are doing professionally during the first five years. Don't haste towards big money or designations but stay hungry to build a solid foundation." This is where Aamir Khan's character from the Three Idiots movie started popping up in my mind saying, "Chase success and the money will chase you."

The formula to one becoming successful in life, as Raja explains, lies in starting to work from the bottom. It is at the bottom, he says, that one can learn the true fundamentals of anything and everything life has to offer.